LEXIN CAI

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CURRENT EMPLOYMENT

Postdoctoral Scholar 2026-
UCLA California Center for Population Research
Mentor: Martha Bailey

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics, Cornell University 2026
Committee: Zhuan Pei, Maria Fitzpatrick, Pauline Leung, Benjamin Goldman

M.S. in Social Policy, University of Pennsylvania 2015

B.S. in Public Administration, Renmin University of China 2013

WORKING PAPERS

"From Means-Tested to Universal: Short- and Long-Run Effects of Free School Meals"

"Screening Out the Needy: The Effects of SNAP Work Requirements"
(with Hyewon Kim and Pauline Leung)

"When Free Lunch Is No Longer a Proxy for Student Poverty: Effects of the Community Eligibility Provision on State K-12 Funding"

WORK IN PROGRESS

"Who is Financially Constrained? How Out-of-Pocket Costs Shape Contraceptive Use, Pregnancy, and Childbirth"
(with Martha Bailey, Emilia Brito, and Giulia Olivero)

"The Effects of Subsidizing Contraception on Educational and Labor Market Outcomes"
(with Martha Bailey, Emilia Brito, and Giulia Olivero)

"Work Requirements in SNAP and Postsecondary Enrollment"
(with Meredith Welch)

PRESENTATIONS

ASSA Annual Meeting (poster) 2027

ASSA Annual Meeting, Institute for Research on Poverty Summer Research Workshop (poster, UW–Madison), National Tax Association Annual Meeting, Ohio State University, Minneapolis Fed, U.S. International Trade Commission, Penn Wharton Budget Model, Mathematica, Analysis Group 2026

APPAM, Association for Education Finance and Policy, FLX Economics of Education Workshop (Cornell), Policy Impacts Annual Conference (MIT), Society for Benefit-Cost Analysis (SBCA), Symposium on the Frontiers in the Studies of Anti-Poverty Programs (Discussant, Cornell) 2025

APPAM 2024

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

Ernest Liu '64, Ta-Chung and Ya-Chao Liu Memorial Fellowship, Cornell	2025–2026
Jerry Ellig Award for Best Student Presentation, SBCA Annual Meeting	2025
Jain Family Institute – Cornell Brooks School Fellow	2023–2024
Outstanding TA Award, Cornell Brooks School of Public Policy	2022
Sage Fellowship, Cornell University (x2)	2020–2025
Dean's Merit Award, University of Pennsylvania	2014
Global KU Scholarship, Korea University	2012
National Scholarship, Renmin University of China (x3, top 5%)	2010–2013

TEACHING

TA for Behavioral Economics and Public Policy, Cornell University	Spring 2022
TA for Economics of the Public Sector, Cornell University	Fall 2021

RESEARCH GRANTS

Russell Sage Foundation Dissertation Research Grant ($15K)	2025
MIT Policy Impacts Early-Career Scholars Grant ($10K)	2024
Cornell Labor Economics Small Grant ($2.5K)	2024

EMPLOYMENT

Cornell University 2022–2024
Research Assistant to Prof. Pauline Leung and Prof. Zhuan Pei

Center on Budget and Policy Priorities 2015–2020
Research Analyst (2018–2020), Associate (2016–2018), Intern (2015–2016)

World Wildlife Fund 2014–2015
Intern

SERVICE

Executive Board Member, Diversity in Cornell Economics	2022–2025
Student Representative, Cornell Economics Committee for Student and Faculty Engagement	2022–2024
Social Co-chair, Cornell Graduate Students in Public Policy	2021–2022
Co-founder, Wonk Tank, Penn Wharton Public Policy Initiative	2014–2015

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Data clearance U.S. Census Bureau Special Sworn Status (2022-present)
Languages English, Cantonese, Mandarin Chinese
Citizenship United States

Last updated October 2026